

# Front-line Aircraft

This decade saw tremendous advances in warplanes. Building on the great progress in technology through the 1960s and utilizing the immense power of turbojet engines, combat aircraft took to the skies in the 1970s and (with appropriate weapons, engine, and technology upgrades) are still defending major nations 50 years later.



△ Mikoyan-Gurevich MiG-23 1970  
**Origin** USSR  
**Engine** 22,000-27,500 lb (9,979-12,474 kg) thrust Tumansky R-29 afterburning turbojet  
**Top speed** 1,519 mph (2,445 km/h)

This swing-wing interceptor with sophisticated radar targeting and beyond-visual-range missiles effectively fixed the weak points of the MiG-21. It was cheap compared with rivals; 5,047 were built.



△ English Electric Lightning F53 1970  
**Origin** UK  
**Engine** 2 x 12,530-16,300 lb (5,684-7,394 kg) thrust Rolls-Royce Avon RA24 Mk 302C afterburning turbojet  
**Top speed** 1,520 mph (2,446 km/h)

The 1967 F53 Export version added ground-attack capability to this supersonic fighter, with its stacked engines and phenomenal performance; this model was used by the Royal Saudi Air Force.



△ Yakovlev Yak-38 1971  
**Origin** USSR  
**Engine** 15,000 lb (6,804 kg) thrust Tumansky R-28 V-300 turbojet, plus 2 x 7,870 lb (3,568 kg) thrust Rybinsk RD-38 turbojet  
**Top speed** 795 mph (1,280 km/h)

The Soviet Navy's only vertical takeoff and landing fighter, guided by its mother ship's computer to land automatically from several miles away, it used its two extra engines for takeoff, but was underpowered.

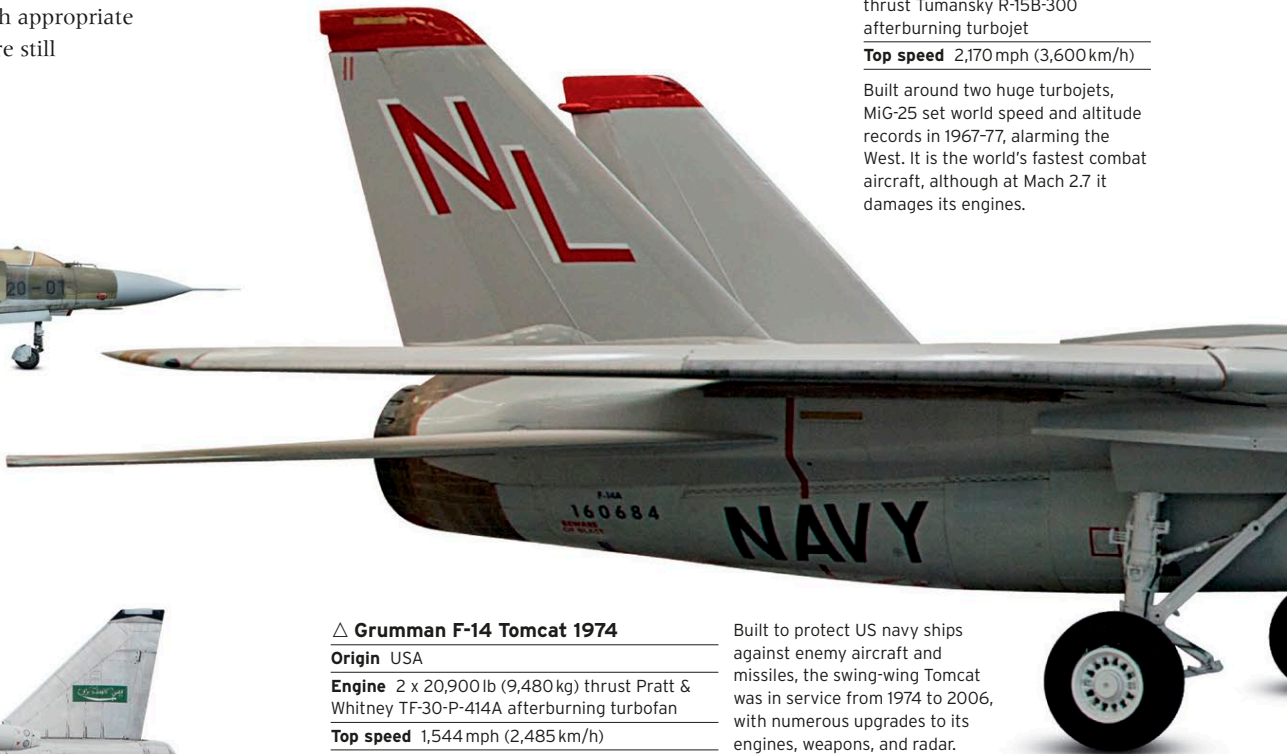
▷ Saab 37 Viggen 1971  
**Origin** Sweden  
**Engine** 16,200-28,110 lb (7,348-12,750 kg) thrust Volvo RM 8A/B afterburning turbofan  
**Top speed** 1,386 mph (2,231 km/h)

The first aircraft with both afterburners and thrust reversers was easy to maintain and operable from a short stretch of road. It had the world's first airborne computer with integrated circuits.



△ Mikoyan-Gurevich MiG-25 "Foxbat" 1970  
**Origin** USSR  
**Engine** 2 x 24,685 lb (11,200 kg) thrust Tumansky R-15B-300 afterburning turbojet  
**Top speed** 2,170 mph (3,600 km/h)

Built around two huge turbojets, MiG-25 set world speed and altitude records in 1967-77, alarming the West. It is the world's fastest combat aircraft, although at Mach 2.7 it damages its engines.



△ Grumman F-14 Tomcat 1974  
**Origin** USA  
**Engine** 2 x 20,900 lb (9,480 kg) thrust Pratt & Whitney TF-30-P-414A afterburning turbofan  
**Top speed** 1,544 mph (2,485 km/h)

Built to protect US navy ships against enemy aircraft and missiles, the swing-wing Tomcat was in service from 1974 to 2006, with numerous upgrades to its engines, weapons, and radar.



△ Hawker Siddeley Harrier 1970  
**Origin** UK  
**Engine** 21,500 lb (9,752 kg) thrust Rolls-Royce Pegasus 103 turbofan  
**Top speed** 730 mph (1,176 km/h)

Developed in the 1960s the "Jump Jet" was the first successful vertical takeoff and landing (VTOL) fighter. It was highly agile, operable from any small clearing or ship deck, but required a very skilled pilot.

